FROM THE

EDITOR-IN-CHIEF

He is well into his tenth year as prime minister, but Narendra Modi pulls off what few other world leaders have managed. He banishes the near-universal factor of anti-incumbency and his popularity rankings defy the law of gravity. In the biannual India Today-CVoter Mood of the Nation (MOTN) survey for August 2023, about 52 per cent feel he is best suited to be PM and an overwhelming 62.7 per cent rate his performance as good or outstanding. Not as high as his January 2023 rating of 71.6 per cent, and well below his August 2020 peak of 78 per cent. But also safely above his nadir of August 2021, when even the harshness of the Covid aftermath had pegged him down only to 54 per cent. He looms large over the political landscape in the exact same way he has since 2014. Everything still revolves around him. He is like a life-force for the BJP, which is structured around his dominating presence. The NDA government is an extension of his personality. Policymaking has the Modi imprint all over it. The very image of India in the world now has his signature on it.

With just a handful of months left for the 2024 general election, Modi is in pole position to attain what no other Indian prime minister after Nehru has done: a third consecutive re-election with a majority for his party. If the Lok Sabha election were to be held now, the BJP is projected to win 287 seats on its own. Lower than the 303 it got in 2019, but still 15 more than the 272 it needs for a simple majority in the 543-member lower house and three more than the January projection of 284. The combined NDA tots up 306, a marginal rise of eight seats from January. The perceptible 47-seat dip from the 353 it got in 2019 reflects a certain attrition around the edges that should give the BJP some cause for caution, but it's still in a comfortable zone.



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One significant development can explain the drop in seats from the 2019 general election and our last opinion poll. The Indian National Developmental Inclusive Alliance, a.k.a. INDIA, did not exist in January 2023. The Opposition has finally come to the realisation that they cannot beat the juggernaut of Modi individually. The opinion poll yields some interesting insights into how equations have changed—or not—for all parties concerned. The anti-BJP bloc registers a combined 193 seats, a 102-seat jump from what the UPA got in 2019. It's also 40 more than the projection for UPA in January 2023. But this is more on account of the new parties that have joined hands, especially the JD(U) in Bihar and the Trinamool Congress in West Bengal. Together, the INDIA bloc is poised to net in a very worthy 41 per cent vote share. That's just 1.6 percentage points below the NDA, but the vote spread and concentration patterns favour the ruling alliance. So INDIA's emergence does not seem to be at the cost of Modi's phalanx.

The other perceptible change is the gradual consolidation of Rahul Gandhi as a credible player. His acceptance levels have risen from 14 to 16 per cent since January 2023—and the graph has been climbing steadily from 7 per cent a year before that. His image has definitely benefitted from his Bharat Jodo Yatra. But again, that does not seem to be at the cost of Modi. Rather, it is to be judged within the pecking order of Opposition leaders, where he is clearly the frontrunner now. His party's graph mirrors that. The Congress is projected to remain the single largest Opposition party, but the formation of INDIA does not seem to have had a major force-multiplying effect on its fortunes. By present reckoning, the Congress tally is set to increase from 52 to 74—a 22-seat gain made lighter by that low base. Indeed, for all the effort expended on Opposition unity, neither Rahul nor the Congress have regained the potency they had even in the years before the 2019 election. As for the BJP, Amit Shah is a frontrunner to succeed Modi, at 29 per cent, with Yogi Adityanath following at 26 per cent.

Just below the range of Modi's glory radar, on terra firma, there are grittier realities. On the economy, the votes that reflect gloom are getting more widespread. Some 34 per cent now feel things will worsen, up from 31 per cent in January; by contrast, only 31 per cent continue to say the economy will improve. Those who feel the burden of daily expenses has become more difficult are a substantial 62 per cent, up two percentage points since January. And the pool of those who think the job situation is very serious has widened from 54 to 56 per cent. Most strikingly, a whopping 81 per cent feel so in the 18-24 age group, the segment directly concerned about jobs. Also, 68 per cent of those who voted NDA in 2019 belong among those who feel we have a jobs crisis. Overall, those disillusioned with the government's performance on this front have risen from 28 per cent to 34 per cent. This parallels another shift: Modi is no more seen as a pro-poor figure. In September 2014, some 43 per cent thought the poor and farmers would benefit most from his rule; only 9 per cent ticked the corporate sector. Despite all the welfare schemes for the poor that Modi has implemented, 55 per cent think his policies benefited big business.

The social universe too registers troubling undercurrents. The strong pro-Modi segment tends to view the communal situation favourably, so the numbers have always been healthy. In January 2021, for instance, some 55 per cent respondents had said communal harmony had improved—the Modi regime's highest in the past two years. But only 41 per cent feel so in August 2023, and even that's two percentage points down since January. More pertinently, 62 per cent Muslims, 61 per cent Christians and 50 per cent Sikhs feel the situation is worse.

The test of Modi's buoyancy is that it endures despite all the stress on the economy and tension on the social front. Even when respondents register disquiet on those points, no commensurately negative undertow ever touches the PM. The sentiment remains that he's one who will right the ills of India. As the election season hots up, there is much in our Mood of the Nation poll that should give the politicians and the rest of us enough food for thought.



(Aroon Purie)

P.S. Three cheers to the team that put India on the moon with Chandrayaan-3. Made the nation proud.